

over, while we were concerned about the demand from the rural market for the first six months of the year, during this festive season even the rural consumers came out in large numbers to make purchases,” he adds. Moreover, the recent Assembly elections in five states also played a positive role in boosting demand as sales picked up in areas where elections took place, he says.

In the consumer durables sector, however, there were mixed signals. While makers of smart televisions and washing machines witnessed a jump in sales of premium products, sales of mass-market products remained subdued. According to Kamal Nandi, Business Head and Executive Vice President of Godrej Appliances, categories like washing machines and refrigerators that traditionally sell well during the festive season recorded high demand, albeit in the premium segment. “Even, surprisingly, the air conditioner category performed well during the festive period. But the mass market segments did not register volume growth. Overall, the business has grown by double digits due to higher offtake of pricier items and price appreciation,” he says.

In the smart TV space, manufacturers struck gold thanks to the ICC Men’s World Cup that was held in India during the period. Per industry estimates, the category recorded a massive 20 per cent growth in sales of TV sets. However, like in the other large white goods items, the sales were more confined to the premium

and large-screen smart TV segment. “This season, we witnessed consumers from even smaller towns moving towards 55- to 65-inch TVs. The 32-inch segment that used to form a large chunk of the overall market a few years ago is now contracting,” says Avneet Singh Marwah, CEO of Super Plastronics, which manufactures smart TVs under the Kodak, Thomson, and Blaupunkt brands.

Meanwhile, in the real estate market, too, sales of residential homes are estimated to have surged

snacks that Indians widely purchase as gifts during the festive period, sales rose even in the rural market. Parle Products witnessed sales picking up as early as August, and it gained momentum closer to Diwali, says Mayank Shah, Senior Category Head at the Mumbai-based packaged foods major. “The rural market responded well after the monsoon and lifted the business in the mass market price segments that were suffering earlier. We have recorded close to 10 per cent growth this Di-

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3.8
million

**TOTAL AUTOMOTIVE
UNITS SOLD THIS
FESTIVE SEASON**

20
per cent

**SURGE IN SMART TV SALES
THIS FESTIVE SEASON, PER
INDUSTRY ESTIMATES**

CONSUMER SENTIMENT

1

All key consumer-facing sectors register double-digit growth during the festive season

2

Automotive sales surge by 19 per cent this festive season, driven by 21 per cent jump in two-wheeler sales

3

Passenger vehicle sales cross the 500,000-mark for the first time in the festive season

4

Residential real estate sales estimated to have surged 10-15 per cent

by double digits, which will boost the overall sales numbers for the October-December quarter by 10-15 per cent over last year, says Anuj Puri, Chairman of real estate consultancy Anarock Group. “We have definitely seen a major surge in both new launches and housing sales this festive season. Several leading developers have a healthy pipeline of new project launches in the festive quarter across the Top 7 cities.”

Not just large-ticket items, in categories like cookies and savoury

wali over last year,” he tells *BT*.

The festive season may be throwing up some encouraging growth numbers, even from the rural market, but industry veterans like Singhania remain cautious, or rather cautiously optimistic. “We need to observe this trend for at least four to five months,” says Singhania. For now, clearly, the numbers are encouraging overall, albeit with some pockets of concern. **BT**

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